

THE FORBIDDEN PROPHET

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CHAPTER ONE: WHAT PEMBERTON BURIED AND WHY HE WAS RIGHT TO BURY IT

I

The oldest wizard to ever serve as head of the Department of Mysteries was Aldric Pemberton, who died in 1441 at the age of one hundred and twelve, and who spent the last thirty-nine years of his life conducting the most systematic campaign of bureaucratic burial in Ministry history. Not out of malice. Out of love—the particular, burdened love of someone who has seen something enormous and has decided, after long and serious deliberation, that the world is not ready for it.

Pemberton discovered the multiverse in 1402. He sailed into a dimensional rift off the Norwegian coast that his own theories had predicted, and he found it: the endless, stacked architecture of other universes, each as real as the one he had left, each carrying people and places and histories that had no connection to his own but that resonated with it at frequencies he spent the rest of his life trying to measure.

He brought back three artefacts. He documented everything. And then he sealed it, locked it, warded it with protections that would take an Omega-clearance holder six centuries of accumulated magical development to undo, and wrote one sentence in his private journal that was not sealed: "The world is not ready. I pray that when it is, the person who opens these files will be braver than I was, and will know what to do."

The person who opened the files was Hermione Granger-Weasley, Chief Unspeakable, on a Wednesday morning when she was trying to locate a document about a different matter entirely. She read Pemberton's full record in six hours. She sent an urgent owl to her husband and her best friend.

The three of them met in Harry's office at midnight.

"He knew," Hermione said, setting the last file down on Harry's desk. "He acquired eight relics from eight universes and he sealed every one of them because he understood what would happen if they were all brought into proximity with a magical nexus of Hogwarts' magnitude."

"What would happen?" Ron asked.

"The convergence. The relics would activate. Something would come through."

Harry had been very still throughout this briefing, in the way that Harry was still when he was processing something that was going to require everything he had.

"And we've already unsealed them," he said. "They've already been brought to Hogwarts."

Hermione looked at him. "Yes."

"So Pemberton wasn't wrong about the world not being ready."

"He wasn't wrong," she said. "He just didn't account for the possibility that readiness isn't always a prerequisite. Sometimes the thing comes whether you're ready or not."

As if the universe had been waiting for exactly that sentence: the emergency alert from Hogwarts hit every Ministry senior officer's wand simultaneously, in the form of a red-flame Patronus that burned the same words into the air in all three of their offices:

"Something is destroying the Forbidden Forest. It breathes like the moon and it cuts like seven centuries of grief. - McGonagall."

CHAPTER TWO: THE ASSET ACTIVATION AND THE ARRIVAL OF WHAT WAS ALWAYS COMING

II

Harry reached Hogwarts first. He always reached things first, and it was rarely because he was the fastest—it was because he was the one most constitutionally incapable of waiting for a plan before moving. Twenty years in the Ministry had smoothed this tendency around the edges; it had not removed it.

The Forbidden Forest was silent in a way that forests are not. There were no owls, no rustling, no distant sound of centaurs moving through the dark. There was simply the cold, the dark, and every fifty metres or so, a tree that had been sheared cleanly in half—not blasted, not burned, but cut, with the surgical precision of a blade that had been perfected over seven centuries of use. Each cut surface was perfectly smooth and oddly cold, as though the sword had not transferred heat but had extracted it. Harry followed the trail inward.

Kokushibo was standing in the clearing at the forest's heart, and he looked exactly like what he was: the most powerful demon alive in his universe, imported into this one, with no obligation and no allegiance and seven hundred years of accumulated certainty that power was the only thing worth having. He had six eyes—four of them arranged above and beside his natural two—and all six were the cold gold of something that had looked at humanity for so long it had forgotten what it felt like to be it. He looked at Harry with the mild curiosity of someone who does not consider the thing in front of them to be a threat.

"You are the one they call the Chosen One," he said. His voice was unhurried. "I have read your history. A boy marked by a killing curse. A boy who survived because his mother loved him. A man who walked into a forest to die and walked back out." He paused. "A powerful story. But it is finished. You are not the answer to the problem I represent."

"I know," Harry said.

Kokushibo looked at him more carefully. He had not expected that.

"I know I'm not the answer," Harry said. "I've known since I read the Chosen One file and the prophecy rewrote itself. I'm not here to fight you." He kept his wand at his side. "I'm here to hold the line long enough for the answer to arrive."

The demon considered this for exactly the length of time it took to determine that it was not a trick. Then, with a movement that was less like drawing a sword and more like a shadow deciding to have an edge, Kokushibo raised his weapon and said: "Then hold it."

The First Form of Moon Breathing opened with a crescent arc of consumed light that cut a thirty-metre swathe through the clearing. Harry threw every Shield Charm in sequence—Protego Maxima, Fianto Duri, Repello Inimicum—and the shields held for three seconds before the second form cut through them like they were suggestions. He rolled, cast a Disillusionment, moved left; the sixth form found him anyway, because light bent toward the blade rather than away from it, and his Disillusionment used light to function.

He was buying time. He knew it. Kokushibo knew it. They both fought accordingly—Kokushibo with measured lethality, each strike a demonstration rather than an execution, and Harry with the unglamorous, grinding survival instinct of someone who had been in impossible situations before and had found that the difference between surviving and not was usually how long you could stay functional. Behind them, unseen in the dark, a dimensional rift was opening. Pemberton's unsealed artefacts were activating. The convergence had begun.

CHAPTER THREE: THE NIGHT THE EIGHT RELICS ANSWERED THE CALL

III

[WAR RECORD MINISTRY CLASSIFICATION: CLASSIFIED EYES ONLY]

The Mobius Chair activated first. It rose from the vault in the Department of Mysteries through the floor of the Time Room, through the atrium ceiling, through the Ministry roof into the night sky and arrived at Hogwarts in twenty seconds, trailing blue-white data-ribbons that the centaurs in the Forest would later describe as "the stars making a new constellation and then thinking better of it."

Hermione, arriving by emergency Portkey, found it waiting in the Hogwarts courtyard with the expectant stillness of a thing that knows it is needed. She sat down without hesitation.

The Chair's response was immediate and total: every tactical truth about the next six hours poured into her mind—not as information she had to process but as clarity she was suddenly standing in. She saw the battle before it happened. She saw the clearing, Harry's position, Kokushibo's forms, the arrival sequence of the other assets. She saw the window forty-seven minutes from now, when Kokushibo's Moon Breathing would reach its peak intensity and then, for exactly twelve seconds, waver, as the human grief beneath it rose to the surface unbidden. She opened her eyes. She sent four Patronuses at once—a precise new skill she had developed in the Department of Mysteries and never had occasion to use—carrying tactical instructions to four specific locations.

Ron arrived at the Hogwarts gate at a sprint, Deputy Minister's robes still half-fastened, his Auror training replacing his sleep-fogged expression with something that had learned to be very, very awake when it needed to be.

"Tell me," he said.

"Forty-seven minutes," Hermione said. "Here's what happens between now and then."

Mjolnir rose from Vault 777 twelve minutes after the Chair. There was no one in the vault when it happened. The surveillance orb in the corner recorded it: the hammer sat motionless for eleven minutes, and then, with the unhurried certainty of an object that operates on its own schedule, it lifted. Not launched—lifted, with the dignity of something rising to meet an occasion. It flew north at a speed that the tracking charms clocked at approximately three hundred kilometres per hour, and it arrived in the Forbidden Forest clearing with a sound like a thunderclap that the whole of Hogsmeade heard in their sleep and folded into their dreams.

It did not land. It hovered, crackling, three feet from Harry Potter—who was bleeding from a cut across his jaw, was down to two functional Shield Charms, and was, by any objective measure, losing—and waited. Kokushibo looked at it. Then at Harry. "The hammer of worthiness," he said. There was something in his six-eyed gaze that was not contempt, and not admiration, but the particular expression of someone who recognises a thing they have thought about before.

"It's not for me," Harry said. He was breathing hard. "Apparently it's been waiting. I just had to keep you occupied long enough for it to get here."

What followed was the most complete deployment of combined inter-universal assets this universe has ever witnessed, and this reporter intends to document every second of it with the precision it deserves.

Anubis Cruger arrived from the East. He came through a dimensional rift that the Mobius Chair had opened on Hermione's instruction, in full S.P.D. Shadow Ranger morph, and he moved through the forest with the efficiency of someone who had been conducting night operations in hostile terrain for forty years. He did not attempt to fight Kokushibo directly—he was not here to fight Kokushibo. He was here to do what he had always done: position people where they needed to be, tell them what they were capable of, and not leave until the mission was complete. He reached the clearing and assessed it in four seconds.

"Potter," he said, not breaking stride, "your left flank has been open for the last fifteen minutes. Move right."

Harry moved right. A Moon Breathing arc that had been tracking his left side cut through empty air.

"Thank you," Harry said.

"Don't thank me," Cruger said. "Hold position. He's not fighting at full capacity."

"He's not?"

"He hasn't used the Upper Moon techniques. He's testing. He wants to see how long you last." A pause. "Longer than he expected. That matters to him, even if he doesn't know it yet."

Xavier's School for Gifted Youngsters manifested at the forest edge at the twenty-second minute. Not the full building—but its essential presence: a radius of sixty metres in which the forest's natural light shifted, and the cold of Kokushibo's Moon Breathing became fractionally less absolute, as though the school's foundational belief that extraordinary beings deserve protection rather than extermination was itself a kind of counter-magic. The centaurs felt it and moved into it instinctively. The castle's wards, already resonating with the convergence, extended toward it like two hands finding each other in the dark.

Kokushibo noticed. His six eyes moved to the edge of his forest and for the first time—the first time in twenty-three minutes of combat—something passed across his face that was not control.

"A school," he said.

"For people the world fears," Harry said. He was standing straighter. The counter-energy from the school's presence had found him. "You were feared before you had done anything to deserve it, weren't you? You were the lesser twin, in a world that ranked people. That's where it started."

The air pressure in the clearing dropped. Moon Breathing flared—not an attack, but an involuntary response, the demonic equivalent of someone flinching.

"You know nothing about where it started," Kokushibo said.

"No," Harry agreed. "But I know someone who does."

At the thirty-second minute, Itachi Uchiha arrived. He came from the north, on foot, in no hurry, as though he had been expecting this moment for some time and had decided the appropriate response was to walk toward it with his full attention. He was dressed plainly. His Sharingan was active—the three-tomoe pattern spinning in slow, deliberate rotation, mapping everything. He stopped at the edge of the clearing and looked at Kokushibo with the particular expression of someone who recognises, in another person, the architecture of a ruin they are intimate with.

Kokushibo turned to face him. Six eyes against two Sharingan. The forest went absolutely still.

"You are the one," Kokushibo said. Not a question. An acknowledgement—grudging, precise, the acknowledgement of someone who has lived long enough to recognise the shape of inevitability.

"I am," Itachi said.

What followed was a battle that the Aurors who arrived at the forest's edge and the centaurs who watched from the trees would spend weeks attempting to describe. Not because the techniques were incomprehensible—though they were extraordinary—but because the emotional register of the fight was unlike anything they had been trained to witness.

Kokushibo opened with the Sixteenth Form, Moon Breathing's apex technique—the full expression of seven centuries of power, crescent arcs layered sixteen deep, each one consuming the light of the others and compounding the darkness into a weapon that moved at a speed no human eye should track. The Forbidden Forest shook. Three hundred metres of trees to the north were sheared to their roots. The ground cracked in concentric circles outward from the impact zone.

Itachi did not dodge. He stood in the centre of it and cast a Genjutsu—not with his hands, not with an incantation, but with his eyes alone: the Tsukuyomi, the most complete illusionary technique his universe has produced, applied at full capacity to an opponent who was also a master of visual combat.

The crescent arcs froze mid-air. The darkness held. Kokushibo stood motionless, his six eyes trapped inside an illusion that was running at one-seventieth of normal time—meaning every second in the real world was seventy seconds inside the Tsukuyomi.

Inside the illusion: a room. Simple. A room that looked like something from both of their histories at once—a room that was the interior of the Uchiha clan compound and also, somehow, the interior of the Tsugikuni family home, six hundred years ago, in a world that no longer existed. And in it, visible to Kokushibo alone: his brother. Yoriichi. Not as an adversary. As the young man he had once been, before the jealousy had calcified into

something unrecognisable. Looking at Michikatsu not with triumph, not with judgment, but with the helpless, honest affection of someone who had always known his brother was in pain and had never found the right words.

In the real world, five seconds passed. Inside the Tsukuyomi, Kokushibo stood in a room with his brother for five hours and fifty minutes. When the illusion released, Kokushibo was on one knee.

Not defeated. Not broken. But kneeling—the posture not of surrender but of something quieter and more devastating: the posture of exhaustion. The exhaustion of someone who has been running from something for seven hundred years and has, in the space of six hours of a November night in a universe that is not his own, run out of ground to run on. His sword was still in his hand. His eyes were still open, all six of them. But the Moon Breathing had gone quiet. The forest's light came back—tentatively, the way light returns after something very large has moved away.

Mjolnir, which had been hovering in the clearing for thirty-two minutes, drifted sideways. Slowly, without drama, moving the way things move when the moment has found them rather than the other way around. It stopped in front of Itachi Uchiha.

Itachi looked at it. He looked at Harry, who was standing twenty feet away and was bleeding from several places and had an expression that said he had known this was coming and had arranged everything around it. He looked at Cruger, who was watching with the expression of a commander who has just seen a recruit do exactly what they were always capable of and is choosing, in this moment, not to speak.

Then Itachi looked at Kokushibo. And said, quietly: "Michikatsu Tsugikuni."

Six eyes. All open. All wet, in a way that demon eyes are not supposed to be.

"I know what it is," Itachi said, "to destroy something you love in the service of something you believe is necessary. I know what it is to carry the consequence alone for so long that the consequence becomes you. I know what it is to be defined by the worst thing you ever did, even when the worst thing you ever did was the only available act of love."

He reached out and took Mjolnir's handle. The hammer blazed.

CHAPTER FOURTH: THE MAP AND THE LAST TRUTH

IV

The light from Mjolnir in Itachi's hand was not lightning. It was something older and warmer—the accumulated worthiness of a man who had never once acted for himself when someone he loved needed him to act otherwise. It filled the Forbidden Forest from edge to edge. It

found every corner that the Moon Breathing had darkened and filled it, not with blinding intensity but with the steady, reliable glow of something that has decided to stay.

Kokushibo looked at the light. His six eyes, for the first time in seven hundred years, blinked. He raised his sword—not to attack. He raised it in the oldest gesture of a warrior's respect: the blade upright, the hilt toward his chest, the point toward the sky. Acknowledging an opponent who had reached him in a place that swords could not reach. Then he set the sword down in the earth. Not dropped—placed, with the careful precision of a man handling something irreplaceable. He sat beside it. He did not speak again that night, and no one asked him to.

Harry reached into his robes and pulled out the Marauder's Map. He had carried it tonight without knowing why—habit, perhaps, or the deep instinct that the Map had always known things he needed to know before he knew he needed them. He unfolded it. The parchment was warm. The familiar ink of corridors, passages, and footprints filled the surface—but the Map had extended, as it had once been capable of doing, far beyond the castle walls and into the forest.

Every person in the clearing showed as a small set of footprints with a name beside it: *Harry James Potter. Hermione Granger-Weasley. Ronald Bilius Weasley. Anubis Cruger. Itachi Uchiha. Michikatsu Tsugikuni.* That last name had not appeared on any map in six hundred years.

At the centre of the clearing, where the convergence had been most intense and where the eight relics were now settling—the Mobius Chair, the Evolution orb, Cruger's tactical dossier, the Chosen One record, all of it gently deactivating, the convergence completing its cycle—the Map showed one additional annotation. New ink, written in a hand Harry had never seen but that the Map had clearly accepted as its own, just as it had accepted the hands of all four of its original makers. He read it aloud, because some things need to be spoken rather than seen:

— RECOVERED TRANSCRIPT —

"I solemnly swear that I am up to no good. That I have always been up to no good, in the specific sense that no good comes from silence, or sealed vaults, or the belief that the world is not ready.

The world is never ready. That is not the world's flaw. That is the world's condition. The people in it are ready, or they are not, and the ones who are ready carry the ones who aren't, and that is the only system that has ever worked.

We found the relics. We unsealed the truth. We assembled the answer. And in a forest in Scotland on a November night, a man who had spent seven hundred years becoming what grief makes of you finally put his sword down.

That is worth every sealed vault in the Department of Mysteries. It is worth every point we spent. It is worth Pemberton's thirty-nine years of careful burial, which was not cowardice—we see that now—but the most patient kind of love: the kind that waits for the moment when it will matter.

The moment was now. The moment was us. The moment was always going to be someone, and it was us."

— The Map, speaking for itself, and for all of us.

The dawn, when it came, came quietly. The forest was whole. The centaurs had returned to their usual paths. Hagrid's hut—which had not been touched—have a fire lit in the chimney, and Hagrid himself was standing at the door with a cup of tea of approximately bucket proportions, looking at the six unlikely figures emerging from the treeline with the expression of a man who has seen most things and found most of them less alarming than other people did.

"Breakfast?" he said.

Ron said yes before anyone else could answer. This was, by any reasonable assessment, the correct decision.

CHAPTER FIVE: EPILOGUE - MISCHIEF MANAGED

V

The official Ministry record of that night says nothing. This is standard. The official Ministry record of most of the things that have mattered in the last three decades says very little, and the things it does say are usually the least important parts of the story. The unofficial record—this one—says the following:

Cruger departed two days later, through a dimensional rift the Mobius Chair opened at his request. He left a four-page debrief that the Auror Office has been using as the basis for a complete overhaul of their defensive formation doctrine. He also left a handwritten note addressed to Harry that said: "You held the line. That's all anyone can ever do. The rest is what arrives when you hold it long enough." Harry has it pinned inside his office desk drawer.

The Mobius Chair returned to its vault. Hermione has since used it exactly once more to check a single personal question that she has declined to share with anyone, including her husband. She came back from the Chair with the expression of someone who has received an answer they were afraid of and found it was kinder than they expected. She did not explain. Ron did not ask. Twenty years of marriage are, among other things, the development of a sophisticated understanding of which things to ask.

Itachi Uchiha departed without ceremony, the way he arrived. Before he left, he stood in the Hogwarts entrance hall for a moment and looked at the school—the suits of armour, the moving portraits, the staircases shifting to their morning configurations, the distant smell of breakfast from the kitchens. He looked at it the way a person looks at something they will carry with them. Then he pressed two fingers to his forehead—the gesture, Harry had learned, that in Itachi's world meant both farewell and I acknowledge you—and he walked into the dimensional rift and was gone.

Kokushibo remained for a week. He did not speak much. He sat, mostly, in the courtyard where the early winter sun was strongest, six eyes open to the light—choosing light, deliberately, the way someone does who has spent too long in the dark. On the fourth day, a Hufflepuff second-year named Ellis sat beside him without invitation and offered him half a biscuit. Kokushibo looked at the biscuit for a long moment. He took it. He did not speak. Neither did Ellis. They sat in the sun until the bell called the students back to class.

On the seventh day, Kokushibo stood in the courtyard and looked at Harry. "I came here to destroy," he said.

"I know," Harry said.

"I did not destroy."

"No. You didn't."

A pause. Six eyes, in the morning light, doing something that was not quite an expression but was the territory immediately adjacent to one.

"The Tsugikuni name," he said finally. "There is no one left to carry it in my universe."

"No," Harry said. "But you're carrying it here." He met the demon's eyes. All six of them. "That counts."

Kokushibo stepped through the dimensional rift. It closed like a page turning.

Harry stood in the empty courtyard. The Map was still in his pocket—it was always in his pocket, had been since he was thirteen, would probably be there when he was ninety and considerably less spry. He unfolded it. The castle mapped itself in its familiar ink. Every corridor. Every passage. Every footprint of every person going about their morning. And in the margin, in the same hand as the forest annotation, one final line:

"I Solemnly Swear That I Was Up To No Good."

He smiled. He got out his own wand and touched it to the parchment.

"Mischief Managed."

The Map went blank. The ink faded. The parchment returned to its ordinary self—old, creased, smelling of something that might be magic and might just be the particular smell of something that has been important for a very long time. He folded it and put it back in his pocket. He went inside. He had a Department of Mysteries briefing in forty-five minutes and three files to unseal before lunch, and Hermione would be annoyed if he was late, and Ron would have already eaten all the good biscuits if he didn't get to the conference room first. Some things do not change. Most of the best things don't.

This account is filed in the Restricted Section of the Department of Mysteries under Pemberton's vault number, beside the eight acquisition files that preceded it. It is sealed with a Fidelius Charm. It will be released when the world is ready for it—and if the last six hundred years have taught us anything, it is that someone will find it at exactly the right time, whether the world considers itself ready or not. That is, after all, how every important thing has ever been found.

END OF PRIVATE ASSET FILE IX

CLASSIFICATION: OMEGA BLACK • FIDELIUS • SEALED
"I SOLEMNLY SWEAR I WAS UP TO NO GOOD" • "MISCHIEF MANAGED"
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